

private high schools in the United States. She's an "average" student, according to her parents. She gets Bs and Cs in a tough school. I asked her some simple questions to see what she knew in math, history, and science. For math, I asked if she knew the square root of nine. For history, I asked if she could name any of the countries that fought in World War II. For science, I asked if she knew at what temperature water freezes.

The girl laughed at me. "I can't answer *those* questions. Can't you give me something easy?"

After several more questions I learned she had heard of Adolf Hitler.

"What do you know about him?" I asked.

"Not very much."

"Let's start with the basics. Overall, was he a good guy or a bad guy?"

She shook her head. "I really couldn't tell you that."

What a child learns in school has more to do with his or her attitude than the school curriculum. More to do with whether parental reinforcement than class size. More to do with whether their parents can read and write than with the school's textbooks. And let's face it: the specific knowledge Johnny learns in the tenth grade hardly prepares him for life's work. We'd like Johnny to learn something before he graduates from high school. We'd like him to be as prepared as possible before he gets to college. But even in the best of circumstances he retains only a tiny fraction of what he's taught. And what he misses during the early years he can make up later.

A friend of mine teaches at one of Southern California's most respected private liberal-arts colleges. The college draws from the top 10 percent of high-school graduates nationwide. Those admitted typically score in the 90th percentile on the SAT. I asked the professor to compare entering students today with those of twenty years ago.

"Students are just as bright today, maybe brighter," he told me. "But they arrive with virtually no preparation.